

CANE TOAD

Rhinella marina

One of the largest toads in the world, the cane toad is a hardy creature with a huge appetite. Also known as the marine toad, it is mainly a resident of dry environments, scrub, and savanna. It commonly lives around human settlements and is often seen under streetlights, waiting for insects to fall. The female is larger than the male, and the largest females can lay more than 20,000 eggs in a single clutch. Males attract females with a slow, low-pitched trill. They have few enemies, as at all stages of their life cycle they are distasteful or toxic to potential predators. In Australia they have become a major pest – they are poisonous to native and domestic animals, injurious to humans, and breed so prolifically as to be out of control.



SIZE 10–24 cm (4–9½ in)

HABITAT Non-forested habitats

DISTRIBUTION C. and S. America;

introduced to Australia and elsewhere

DIET Terrestrial invertebrates

parotoid gland

adult coloration is yellow,
olive, or reddish brown

warts on male's skin
develop dark, sharp spines
in the breeding season

NIGHT HUNTER >

Protected by their poisonous skin and unafraid of predators, cane toads emerge at night from their daytime hiding places to hop about in search of prey.



dark belly
markings

short legs have
powerful muscles
for jumping

^ PALE BELLY

The cane toad's belly and throat are relatively smooth, and mostly pale in colour. Toads have permeable skin and must hide by day to conserve water.

DEBATE

PEST CONTROL

The cane toad gets its name from Australia, where it was introduced into Queensland in 1935 to control insect pests on sugar cane farms. The toads flourished in Australia, feasting on native fauna and building up much denser populations than in their native habitat. Still spreading at an alarming rate, they now occur throughout eastern and northern Australia, and are likely to migrate further. Scientists are working on methods to limit their numbers and contain their territorial expansion.

